

The Miller's Debt

A demonstration

4 CHARACTERS AT LEVEL 3 · 7 SEGMENTS · RUNS TO 2:00 · 6 CREATURES · 3 ENCOUNTERS

Chapter One — Ashfen

The village, and what it will not say

0:00 — 0:15

The causeway

- Open on the wagon, the last of the light, and a village that is four miles further than the map said.
- The carter will not go past the fen boundary and will not say why. He waits for his money at the stone, not in the village.
- ★ A scarecrow in the third field has its head turned to watch the road. If a player points at it, agree with them and move on.
- Ask each player what their character is hoping is waiting at the end of this road. Write the answers down — the Whisper legendary action in scene 6 uses them.
- End the scene the moment they can hear the mill wheel. They should hear it before they see it.

Prep note. Cold open on the road. Get names and one sentence of why each of them is this far out.

Images for the players' screen: The causeway at dusk

0:15 — 0:40

Ashfen

- The village is sixty people and every one of them is polite and none of them will discuss the mill.
- ★ SISTER HALLOWAY at the chapel will talk. The miller has been gone eleven days. Nobody has gone to look. She is ashamed of that and says so.
- ★ WICK, the miller's boy, is throwing stones at the water and not going home. He has a drawing (Tools → handouts). Give it to them without comment.
- The reeve's man came through nine months ago and again in the spring. Two people mention it and both change the subject.
- If they ask to see the mill, everyone finds a reason to be elsewhere. Halloway will come with them. Wick will follow whether they let him or not.
- Time check: leave here by 0:40 even if they have not found everything.

Prep note. Three things to find here. Let them get two. The third is the one they will wish they had.

Images for the players' screen: Ashfen from the water

0:40 — 0:55

FIGHT: the scarecrow field

- Four scarecrows, three fence rows, two ditches of standing water. Nothing is moving.
- ★ Let the players start this fight. They will spend a full minute deciding, and that minute is the scene.
- Fire is the obvious answer and everything is soaked — let them try it, let it half-work, and give them the win for thinking of it.
- The hounds come out of the reeds on round two, from behind.
- Anyone who ends their turn in a ditch has started the Damp clock (Tools tab). Say so out loud the first time, then stop reminding them.

Prep note. The only route to the mill crosses the barley. They do not move until the party does something.

The fight: The scarecrow field — Ashfen · the drowned barley, dusk

4× Bog Scarecrow · 2× Fen Hound

800 XP — Low–Moderate

They do not move until the party gives them a reason. Fire is the answer and the field is soaked — let someone try anyway.

The ditch is chest-deep water; anyone who ends a turn in it starts the Damp clock.

Chapter Two — The Mill

Everything the village would not say

0:55 — 1:15

The mill house

- The house is tidy. The bed is made. There is eleven days of dust and one clean patch on the table where something was taken away.
- ★ THE STRONGBOX — four dials and a rhyme (Tools → handouts). Answer: water, wheel, wheat, moon. A wrong order costs 1d4 and a minute of poison, never a lockout.
- Inside: 31 gold, the deed, and the tax letter. The letter is the why — he could not pay.
- Wick knows his father worked nights. He will say so unprompted if anyone asks about the man rather than the mill.
- The wheel is turning. Nothing is driving it. Nobody has opened the sluice in eleven days.
- End on someone looking out at the millpond and realising the water is moving the wrong way.

Prep note. The puzzle scene. The strongbox is under the floor by the grain hopper.

Images for the players' screen: The millpond by moonlight

FIGHT: the drowned wheel

Added by Claude — Filled in the key beats — your outline gives this fight one line ('the pond ones come out'), so the shape of the scene is mine.

- They come up out of the water without a sound. The first anyone knows is the cold.
- ★ If Sister Halloway is with them, this is her scene — Turn Undead, and she is visibly terrified while she does it.
- The millers try to grapple and drag toward the water, not to kill. Being pulled in starts the Damp clock.
- One of the millers is wearing an apron with a name stitched into it, and it is not the missing man's name. There were others.
- Keep Wick out of it. He hides, and he watches, and he does not run.

Prep note. Two millers out of the pond, two hounds from the yard gate. Halloway's Turn Undead is the moment here.

The fight: The drowned wheel — The mill yard · first hour of the night

2× Drowned Miller · 2× Fen Hound

1,300 XP — Moderate–High

Two of them come up out of the millpond and one is already behind the party, in the water butt by the gate. Sister Halloway's Turn Undead lands here if she has followed them out.

FIGHT: Old Grist

- Do not put her model down at the start. Roll her initiative, say nothing, and let her come up out of the race behind whoever is closest to the wheel.
- ★ THE FIGHT IS THE LEVER. She regains 8 HP at the start of every turn while she is in running water; a DC 13 Athletics check on the north wall closes the sluice and stops it for good. The pop-up will remind you.
- ★ WHISPER (legendary action) — she says one true thing about a character in their parent's voice. Use the answers from scene 1. This is the payoff.
- Call the Race floods the whole floor once per fight. Everyone but her is in difficult terrain and the Damp clock is running for the rest of the night.
- The miller is at the bottom of the race, and he is still turning the wheel, and he is not going to stop.
- Two scarecrows come down the ladder on round two. They are a clock, not a threat — they are there to stop the party turtling.
- If the party is losing badly: Halloway steps into the water. That is the out, and it costs her.

Prep note. The boss. She is in the race and does not surface until her first turn. The sluice lever ends her regeneration.

The fight: Old Grist — Inside the wheelhouse · the last twenty minutes

1× Old Grist · 2× Bog Scarecrow

2,000 XP — 1.3× High

She is in the race, under the wheel, and she does not come up until her first turn. Two scarecrows come down the ladder on round two. The lever on the north wall closes the sluice and ends her regeneration — that is the fight.

Images for the players' screen: Inside the wheelhouse

Epilogue — what the water gives back

- With the sluice shut, the wheel stops for the first time in eleven days, and the whole valley notices the silence.
- The village comes out. Nobody apologises. Somebody has already brought bread.
- ★ Wick asks whether his father waved. Let the player who is holding the drawing answer that. Do not answer it yourself.
- The deed is in the strongbox and the mill has no miller. Offer it to them and see what they say.
- Last image: the millpond, flat and still, and one set of footprints in the mud going down into it that nobody made tonight.

Prep note. Five minutes. Do not extend it. End on Wick.

Handouts and puzzles

The strongbox lid — the puzzle

Four brass dials, each stamped with a picture: a wave, a wheel, a sheaf of wheat, a moon.

Scratched into the lid above them, in a hand that pressed too hard:

“What comes first has no hands.

What comes next is turned by it.

What comes third is broken by that.

And what comes last is my only witness.”

[image attached in the tracker]

Yours only. SOLUTION — press them in this order: WATER, WHEEL, WHEAT, MOON.

Water has no hands. The wheel is turned by the water. The wheat is broken by the wheel. And the moon was his only witness, because he milled at night — which is the thing the party has not worked out yet.

A wrong order: the lid spits a needle. DC 12 Dexterity save or 1d4 piercing and Poisoned for 1 minute. It will do this every time; it never locks them out.

HINTS, in order of cheapness:

- Wick, unprompted, if anyone asks about his father's hours: “He worked nights. Mam hated it.”
- DC 12 Investigation on the mill floor: fresh grain dust only under the north window, where the moon comes in.
- If they are properly stuck, let Sister Halloway read the rhyme aloud and stop, deliberately, on ‘my only witness’.

Inside: 31 gold, a deed, and the letter (the next handout).

The letter in the strongbox

To the miller of Ashfen, greetings.

The tithe on your mill is forty-one gold and is now nine months in arrears. The Reeve is minded to be patient. The Reeve is not minded to be patient twice.

You will understand that a mill which does not pay is a mill which does not grind, and a village which does not grind is a village which moves. We would all prefer it did not come to that.

You have until the first frost.

— by the hand of Corwen Vail, for the Reeve of Marchford

Yours only. This is the WHY. He could not pay, so he took the deal that was offered to him at the water's edge, and he has been milling at night for something that does not eat bread.

It is dated eleven months ago. The first frost was two months ago.

If a player asks what he was grinding — that is the right question, and the answer is at the bottom of the race in scene 6. Do not answer it here.

Wick's drawing

Added by Claude — Invented — your notes say the boy 'knows more than he is saying' but never say what, and the party needs one concrete thing to hold before the mill.

[image attached in the tracker]

Yours only. Give them this without comment. Wick drew it three days ago and his mother took it off the wall.

It is the mill, the wheel, and a stick figure standing inside the wheel with its arms out. Underneath, in a nine-year-old's hand: 'dad'.

He will tell you, if asked gently, that he sees his father in the wheel most nights, and that his father waves. He does not think this is frightening. He thinks everyone is being strange about it.

This is the first hard evidence that the miller is not simply missing, and it should land about fifteen minutes before the party is ready for it.

Campaign mechanics

The Damp

Ashfen water does not want to let go of you.

A creature that has been in the millwater makes a Constitution save when it gets out, and again for every further 10 minutes it stays in. The tier is total time in the water tonight, not time since the last save. Getting properly dry and warm clears the count — not the exhaustion.

TIME IN THE WATER	DC	ON A FAILURE	ON A SUCCESS
Up to 10 minutes	10	1 level of Exhaustion	No effect
10–30 minutes	13	1 Exhaustion, and roll on What the Water Says	1 Exhaustion
Over 30 minutes	16	2 Exhaustion, and speed is halved until a long rest	1 Exhaustion
Held under by Old Grist	—	No save. See her Millstone Grip — this is drowning, not the Damp.	—

What the Water Says (d6)

- 1 You hear your own name, from under the surface, in your own voice.
- 2 Everything you are carrying is suddenly, impossibly heavy. Drop something or move at half speed.
- 3 You are certain the water is warmer further down.
- 4 For a moment you can see perfectly clearly underwater, and there is somebody standing on the bottom.
- 5 Your lantern gutters and burns green. It gives no warmth for an hour.
- 6 You are dry. Your clothes are dry, your hair is dry, and nobody else can see it.

Getting dry. A short rest by a fire clears the running count. It does not remove exhaustion — that needs a long rest, or Sister Halloway's Lesser Restoration, of which she has exactly two.

Why it exists. So that wading is a decision rather than free movement. Every map in this oneshot has water on it, and the players should be weighing whether to cross it or go the long way round.

Creatures

Bog Scarecrow CR 1/2 · 100 XP

Small Construct, Unaligned

AC 13 **HP** 27 (5d8+5) **Speed** 30 ft. **Con save** +3

STR 14 (+2) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 4 (-3) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 5 (-3)

Saves Con +3 · PP 10 · Darkvision 60 ft.

Straw and Salt. Immune to poison and to being Poisoned. **Vulnerable to fire** — and the party will work that out fast.

False Appearance. While it stays still it is indistinguishable from an ordinary scarecrow.

Multiattack. Two Claws.

Claw. +4, reach 5 ft, 1d6+2 slashing.

Terrifying Glare. One creature within 30 ft that can see it: DC 11 Wisdom save or Frightened until the end of its next turn.

At the start of combat — **They are not moving yet.** All four stand exactly where the field says they should. Nothing happens until someone touches the fence line, crosses the ditch, or attacks. Let the players decide to start this fight.

Fen Hound CR 1 · 200 XP

Added by Claude — Statted at CR 1 — your notes say 'something in the reeds that hunts in twos', so the name and every number here are mine.

Medium Beast, Unaligned

AC 13 **HP** 26 (4d8+8) **Speed** 40 ft., swim 30 ft. **Con save** +4

STR 15 (+2) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 3 (-4) **WIS** 12 (+1) **CHA** 6 (-2)

Saves Con +4 · Skills Perception +3, Stealth +4 · PP 13

Pack Tactics. Advantage on an attack roll if an ally is within 5 ft of the target and not Incapacitated.

Keen Smell. Advantage on Perception checks that rely on smell — it will find anyone hiding in the reeds.

Bite. +4, reach 5 ft, 1d8+2 piercing, and the target makes a DC 12 Strength save or is knocked Prone.

Drowned Miller CR 2 · 450 XP

Medium Undead, Neutral Evil

AC 12 **HP** 45 (7d8+14) **Speed** 25 ft., swim 30 ft. **Con save** +4

STR 16 (+3) **DEX** 12 (+1) **CON** 15 (+2) **INT** 8 (-1) **WIS** 10 (+0) **CHA** 6 (-2)

Saves Con +4 · PP 10 · Darkvision 60 ft.

Waterlogged. Water is not difficult terrain for it, and it can hold a creature under without needing to breathe.

Multiattack. Two Slams.

Slam. +5, reach 5 ft, 1d8+3 bludgeoning plus 1d4 cold.

Drag Under. If both Slams hit the same creature, that creature makes a DC 13 Strength save or is Grappled (escape DC 13) and pulled 10 ft toward the water.

Spells (save DC 11). *Ray of Frost* (cantrip), *Fog Cloud* (1)

Cold Grip (1/fight). Once per fight: as a bonus action after a Slam hits, the target is also Restrained until the end of its next turn (escape DC 13).

Old Grist CR 5 · 1,800 XP

Large Fey, Neutral Evil

AC 16 **HP** 95 (10d10+40) **Speed** 30 ft., swim 40 ft. **Con save** +7

STR 18 (+4) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 18 (+4) **INT** 13 (+1) **WIS** 15 (+2) **CHA** 12 (+1)

Saves Con +7, Wis +5 · Skills Deception +4, Perception +5 · PP 15

Millstone Grip. A creature hit by Grind is Grappled (escape DC 15). She can only hold one at a time, and she holds it **under the water**.

Legendary Resistance (2/Day). When she fails a save, she may choose to succeed instead.

Multiattack. One Grind and one Fen Chill.

Grind. +7, reach 10 ft, 2d8+4 bludgeoning.

Fen Chill. +7, reach 5 ft, 2d6+4 cold, and the target's speed drops 10 ft until the end of its next turn.

Legendary Actions (3/turn). **Wade** — move half speed through water without provoking. **Sluice** (costs 2) — the wheel surges: every creature in the water makes a DC 15 Strength save or is moved 15 ft along the race. **Whisper** — she says one true thing about a character in their own parent's voice; DC 13 Wisdom save or Frightened of her until the end of their next turn.

Spells (save DC 14). *Ray of Frost* (cantrip), *Fog Cloud* (1), *Hold Person* (2), *Misty Step* (2)

Call the Race (1/fight). Once per fight, as an action: the sluice opens and the whole wheelhouse floor becomes waist-deep. Difficult terrain for everyone but her, and the Damp clock starts running.

At the start of combat — She starts under the water. Nobody sees her until she acts. Roll her initiative but do not put a model down until her first turn — she comes up out of the race behind whoever is nearest the wheel.

At the start of combat — The sluice lever is on the north wall. A DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check closes the gate. That switches off her regeneration for good. Wick knows where the lever is and will point at it if anyone asks him.

At the start of its turn — Millrace Renewal. Regains 8 hit points at the start of her turn while any part of her is in running water. Closing the sluice gate ends this.

Wick CR 1/8 · 25 XP · NPC / ally

Small Humanoid (child), Neutral Good

AC 12 **HP** 11 (2d6+2) **Speed** 30 ft. **Con save** +1

STR 8 (-1) **DEX** 14 (+2) **CON** 12 (+1) **INT** 11 (+0) **WIS** 13 (+1) **CHA** 12 (+1)

Skills Stealth +4, Perception +3 · PP 13

He is nine. He is not a combatant and will not fight. If a fight starts, he hides.

Knows the mill. Where the sluice lever is, which boards are rotten, and that his father worked nights.

Will not leave. He will not go back to the village while his father is still down there, whatever anyone says.

Sister Halloway CR 2 · 450 XP · NPC / ally

Medium Humanoid, Lawful Good

AC 16 **HP** 33 (6d8+6) **Speed** 30 ft. **Con save** +3

STR 12 (+1) **DEX** 10 (+0) **CON** 13 (+1) **INT** 12 (+1) **WIS** 16 (+3) **CHA** 13 (+1)

Saves Wis +5 · Skills Insight +5, Medicine +5 · PP 15

Mace. +4, reach 5 ft, 1d6+2 bludgeoning. She is not good at this and knows it.

She will run out. Five spell slots, and then she is a woman with a mace. Play her generously early and let the party feel it when she is empty.

Spells (save DC 13). *Sacred Flame* (cantrip), *Cure Wounds* (1), *Bless* (1), *Lesser Restoration* (2), *Spiritual Weapon* (2)

Channel Divinity: Turn Undead (1/fight). DC 13 Wisdom save or the undead is Frightened and must move away for 1 minute. This works on the Drowned Millers and it is her best round.

Printed from the Table Aid tracker. **4 items are still marked as added by Claude** — those passages are flagged in red above.
Unofficial fan tool; no affiliation with Wizards of the Coast.